I had played with Tim Southee, their right-arm fast-medium bowler, for Essex. He summed up their approach perfectly: ‘I tried sledging. I tried being that tough macho man, but it just felt so awkward. It wasn’t me. My way of playing is to give a little gyp, but not to be afraid of laughing at the funny moments. You have to be comfortable in yourself.’

That was the perfect message, at the perfect time, for an England team that had moved on from the more austere, methodical and introverted side that enjoyed such success under Andy Flower. We were less consistent, perhaps more naturally talented, and certainly more free-spirited. In psychological terms, we had more yellows and greens. I could be more relaxed with them as a leader.

It’s funny. When your career is in the books, you forget the dark moments, and even some of the highs, but I’ll remember that 124-run victory against the Kiwis in the first Test at Lord’s in late May for a long, long time. The 100th match between the countries, it was sensational, one of the best I’ve played in. The old place was rocking, and the game ebbed and flowed marvellously; a record 1,610 runs were scored.

You don’t often come from behind in the way we did, fighting back from 30–4 on the first morning, conceding a first-innings deficit of 134, and securing our fifth win in seven Tests with less than ten overs to spare. Ben Stokes was brilliant, following 92 in the first innings with an eighty-five-ball 100 in the second. He provided further momentum by taking the wickets of Kane Williamson and McCullum in successive deliveries.

My 162 in the second innings was one of my best, for several reasons. I batted instinctively, with freedom and fluency, despite admitting to Farby on the third day, when I was 32 not out overnight, that I was still struggling with the stress of captaincy. He revealed the essence of his coaching style, which involves a basic understanding of the human condition, by suggesting we talk over a beer.

He would revert to his role as assistant for the Ashes once Trevor Bayliss had been confirmed as head coach, and had the perfect personality for a number two. Across sport, they tend to be the guy players unload upon, use almost as a conduit of emotion. Farby’s easygoing nature was summed up in his team talk before the one-day series against the Kiwis: ‘Fuck it. Let’s just go and whack it.’

Trevor is very quiet, a lot cleverer than he lets on. His mask is to play the Aussie fool, the man in the floppy hat who sits at the corner of an outback